Teaching and Learning in Nursing 000 (2026) 1–6

Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Teaching and Learning in Nursing

journal homepage: www.journals.elsevier.com/teaching-and-learning-in-nursing

Research

# A qualitative exploration of nursing students' readiness to transition into the profession

Johanna Salberg[1,2,3], Katarina Hjelm[1], Anja Saletti[1], Lisa Hultin[1,4*]

[1] Department of Public Health and Caring Sciences, Uppsala University, Uppsala, Sweden
[2] Department of Health, Education and Technology, Luleå University of Technology, Luleå, Sweden
[3] Department of Caring Sciences, Marie Cederschiöld University, Stockholm, Sweden
[4] Geriatrics, Rehablilitation Medication and Pain Centre, Uppsala University Hospital, Uppsala, Sweden

ARTICLE INFO

*Article History:*
Accepted 19 August 2026

*Keywords:*
Experiences
Nursing
Nursing students
Qualitative
Readiness
Transition

ABSTRACT

*Background:* The final semester of nursing education is a stressful period as students prepare to transition from academic training to professional practice. This transition requires readiness, including clinical competence, psychological preparedness, and the ability to apply theoretical knowledge in patient care.
*Objective:* To explore how nursing students nearing graduation describe their transition into their future roles as registered nurses.
*Design:* Qualitative exploratory design.
*Setting:* A university in Sweden.
*Participants:* Twelve final-semester nursing students.
*Methods:* Data were collected through focus group interviews (n = 3) and individual interviews (n = 5) between November 2022 and January 2023. Inductive qualitative content analysis was applied.
*Results:* One overarching theme emerged: Leaving security—transitioning into an unpredictable storm with a feeling of ambivalent readiness. Five categories were identified: Reflecting on the nurse's role, Feeling ready but insecure, Continued learning process after graduation, Challenges and concerns regarding future profession, and Dealing with uncertainty in the new role.
*Conclusions:* Students felt prepared and eager to begin professional practice while recognizing its complexity and challenges. They remained confident, humble, and optimistic in facing their new role.
© 2026 The Authors. Published by Elsevier Inc. on behalf of Organization for Associate Degree Nursing. This is an open access article under the CC BY license (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/)

## Background

The final semester before graduation is often the most stressful period for nursing students (Zheng et al., 2022). Newly graduated nurses are expected to demonstrate sufficient knowledge, clinical reasoning, and ethical competence to manage real-life responsibilities (AlMekkawi & El Khalil, 2020). Nursing competence, together with available healthcare resources, strongly influences patient outcomes and mortality (McHugh et al., 2021). Despite this, the transition into practice is known to be difficult, with many newly graduated nurses intending to leave their positions or the profession entirely (Hallaran et al., 2021), often due to emotional exhaustion and workplace incivility (Laschinger et al., 2016). Similar challenges also affect experienced nurses, who report feeling undervalued, stressed, unsupported, and dissatisfied with leadership as aspects influencing intention to leave (Bäckström et al., 2024). If the intentions to leave are realized, high nurse turnover may lead to understaffing that poses risks for patient safety and care quality, as nurse-to-patient ratios are critical for positive outcomes (McHugh et al., 2021).

Transition readiness refers to the individual's preparedness to assume new professional roles, integrating clinical skills, psychological readiness, and theory-practice application (Meleis et al., 2000). Studies among new graduates have explored readiness and emotional needs (Baumann et al., 2019; Tawash et al., 2024). Supportive mentorship and gradually increasing responsibilities can strengthen readiness in early career stages (Baumann et al., 2019).

During the COVID-19 pandemic, public appreciation for nurses increased (Blau et al., 2023), and the experiences of new graduates and final-year students during this period have been investigated (Aukerman et al., 2022; Bani et al., 2023; Luo et al., 2023). Reported challenges include fear, emotional conflict, insufficient coaching, sudden autonomy, and difficulties in clinical training (Aukerman et al., 2022; Bani et al., 2023; Luo et al., 2023). Nursing students' lives were significantly disrupted, with concerns about educational quality and

*Corresponding author.
*E-mail address:* lisa.hultin@uu.se (L. Hultin).

https://doi.org/10.1016/j.teln.2026.08.019
1557-3087/© 2026 The Authors. Published by Elsevier Inc. on behalf of Organization for Associate Degree Nursing. This is an open access article under the CC BY license (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/)

Please cite this article as: J. Salberg et al., A qualitative exploration of nursing students' readiness to transition into the profession, Teaching and Learning in Nursing (2026), https://doi.org/10.1016/j.teln.2026.08.019

challenges in clinical placements (Heilferty et al., 2021; Rohde et al., 2022). For students in Swedish nursing education, most learning activities shifted to digital platforms such as Zoom (Langegård et al., 2021). Reduced social interaction during distance education negatively affected motivation and clinical learning (Langegård et al., 2021; Rohde et al., 2022). These circumstances underscore the need to understand how nursing students perceive their upcoming transition to practice. No previous research has examined readiness among nursing students whose education was largely digital due to the pandemic.

In summary, the transition from a nursing student to a newly graduated nurse has long been a subject of interest in both clinical practice and nursing research. Although this transition has been explored in different contexts, very few studies have explored how the COVID-19 pandemic influenced nursing students' expectations and thoughts about entering professional practice. Therefore, this study aimed to explore how nursing students nearing graduation described their anticipated transition into their future roles as nurses.

## Methods

### *Design*

A qualitative exploratory design was employed, using semistructured interviews to collect data to capture students' perspectives.

### *Theoretical framework*

This study adopts an inductive qualitative content analysis; therefore, the theoretical framework was not integrated into the analysis process but is used to discuss the findings. Benner's *From Novice to Expert* theory describes how nurses develop clinical expertise through experience and reflection and highlights professional transitions, such as graduation and new roles, as key to competence development (Benner, 1984). Support, mentorship, and continued learning are essential during these transitions, which have led to interventions such as internships and transition programs. The transition from student to registered nurse requires readiness for a new professional role, including clinical competence, psychological preparedness, and the integration of theory into practice (Meleis et al., 2000). Although practice readiness often focuses on cognitive, professional, and clinical competencies, it has been criticized for overlooking humanistic aspects of high-quality care (Mirza et al., 2019). Therefore, this study adopts a broad concept of readiness informed by both Benner's developmental perspective and transition theory.

### *Study setting and participants*

This study was conducted at one of the largest universities in Sweden, which educates approximately 50,000 students, 30,000 of which are full-time. The medical faculty at the university offers a three-year nursing education program at the bachelor's level. Each semester, approximately 150 students are accepted into the nursing program, and around 80–90 students graduate at the end of each term. A purposive sampling strategy was used to recruit students during their last semester in the bachelor's-level nursing education and who could provide rich information relevant to the study aim, thereby enabling an in-depth understanding of the phenomenon (Patton, 2015). All students enrolled in the final semester of the nursing program during the winter of 2022/2023 were eligible to participate and were invited via an email sent to their student accounts. Students who were interested in participating contacted one of the researchers (LH or AS) via email. Thereafter, LH provided further details about the study, a written consent form, and a brief questionnaire to collect demographic background data. Completed consent forms and demographic questionnaires were submitted by participants via a designated mailbox at the department's administration office.

### *Data collection*

Data were collected between November 2022 and January 2023 using semistructured focus group interviews and individual interviews. Two female registered nurses experienced in qualitative research methods, including planning, interviewing, and qualitative analysis (LH and JS), collected all the data. Both participated during all interviews, alternated roles as moderator, who leads the interview and observer, who observed the interaction and body language, took notes, summarized and followed up with questions when needed (Krueger & Casey, 2015). The semistructured interview guide included questions focusing on the participants' thoughts on completing their nursing education and their future professional roles and work as registered nurses. The interview guide was generated through joint discussions in the research group and pilot tested in one focus group; nonsubstantive changes were made, and the pilot interview was included in the study. Probing questions were used as appropriate to elicit further detail. The interviews were conducted digitally over Zoom and lasted between 21 and 67 minutes (median: 41 minutes). All interviews were audio-recorded, and both descriptive and reflective field notes were taken. The recordings were transcribed verbatim. Three focus group interviews (two to three participants/group) and five individual interviews were conducted; the same interview guide was used in all interviews. The interview climate was open with fluent discussions and lively interactions.

### *Data analysis*

The data were analyzed using inductive qualitative content analysis. This method is data-driven, in which categories are generated from the data rather than guided by predefined theories. Through close, iterative reading and open coding, patterns are identified and organized into higher-order categories that reflect participants' perspectives (Patton, 2015). The transcripts were read multiple times to gain a comprehensive understanding of the data, followed by line-by-line analysis to identify meaning units relevant to the study aim (Patton, 2015). These were coded as closely to the text as possible; the first and last authors conducted the initial coding. Thereafter, the codes were compared in reflexive discussions to address potential disagreements, aiming to achieve a common understanding. The codes were then compared and organized into categories based on similarities and differences. Categorization was discussed with the coauthors. The results are presented in categories and an overarching theme. The names of the categories were derived inductively from the data, and an overarching theme also emerged during the analysis.

### *Ethical considerations*

The study adhered to the Declaration of Helsinki (World Medical Association, 2013) and Swedish law (Law Concerning the Ethical Review of Research Involving Humans, 2003). Ethical approval from a research ethics committee was not required, as the study did not involve processing of sensitive personal or health data, nor did it pose any physical or psychological harm to participants. Necessary permissions were obtained from the relevant authority, including the head of the nursing program committee and the head of the Department at the University. Written informed consent was obtained from the participants, outlining voluntary participation, the right to withdraw at any time without explanation, and assurance of confidentiality using pseudonymized data, handled/stored in accordance with regulations.

Please cite this article as: J. Salberg et al., A qualitative exploration of nursing students' readiness to transition into the profession, Teaching and Learning in Nursing (2026), https://doi.org/10.1016/j.teln.2026.08.019

*Findings*

A total of 12 students participated in the study (Table 1). Ten students had prior experience working in healthcare, either as a nursing assistant, personal assistant, or mental health worker. Several students (n = 7) had already secured employment as registered nurses, while ten planned to take some time off after graduation.

*Theme and categories*

The analysis revealed one overarching theme: Leaving security—transitioning into an unpredictable storm with a feeling of ambivalent readiness, and five categories (Fig. 1).

Altogether, the students' descriptions revealed an ambivalence in emotions, ranging from feelings of readiness to insecurity. As they prepared to leave their secure roles as students and transition into the role of professional nurses, they described stepping into an unpredictable healthcare system with a mix of confidence and concern. While they believed they had the tools needed to succeed, they remained uncertain whether these would be sufficient to manage the demands of their new professional role.

*Reflecting on the nurse's role in healthcare and society*

Students expressed gratitude for entering an important profession and emphasized the need to use and advocate for their evidence-based knowledge to improve practice. During their education, they gained a deeper understanding of the knowledge and responsibility required of nurses. The COVID-19 pandemic contributed to this shift and was perceived to have increased the status of both nursing and nursing education, leading to greater respect for their career choice.

> I really thought it would be…fantastic after the pandemic. I joked with my husband… "Talk about a woman who's timed this perfectly…we'll be earning twice as much…have amazing working hours after COVID-19…they finally realized what an incredible job this is". (Interview 8)

A discrepancy between educational ideals and clinical reality was described. Although they felt well prepared with broad knowledge and skills for generalist nursing, clinical practice often appeared more specialized. They noted inconsistencies in responsibilities, with some nursing tasks delegated to nursing assistants, leading them to question role boundaries and expectations.

> It feels a bit like there's a gap between how you'd like to work, based on what you learn during training, and what's actually practiced in reality. The theory teaches me how it should be done, but in reality, it often seems quite different. (Interview 6)

**Table 1**
Characteristics of the study population

| Variable | Total (n = 12) |
|---|---|
| Gender (n) | |
| Male | 1 |
| Female | 11 |
| Age (years)[1] | 29 (23–51) |
| Previous experience of university studies (n) | 7 |
| Experience of working in healthcare (n) | 10 |
| Time of working experience in healthcare (month and years)[1] | 4.5 years (3 month–15 years) |

[1] Values are median (range).

*Feeling ready but insecure*

As their education came to an end, students described increasing confidence in their professional role and felt they had acquired the basic knowledge and skills needed for practice. They looked forward to starting work and regarded nursing as a meaningful profession. At the same time, readiness coexisted with uncertainty about their own capabilities. Nevertheless, they were determined to take the leap into their new role.

> Sure, I can do it, but there's an awful lot you can't do. This five-week introduction feels like I'd need five years of introduction if I'm going to start working. (Interview 8)

Self-doubt regarding skills, intellect, and accomplishments was evident in the students' accounts, as they questioned how anyone would dare to employ them and allow them to work in healthcare. At the same time, they looked forward to being independent and in control of their work, although this was also described as unreal, terrifying, and challenging. They reflected on having gone through potential situations in theory but remained uncertain about what the reality would entail.

> It is…something of a roller coaster. The experience can vary…during certain periods, one feels…anxious and wonders whether one will…be able to manage work. Experiences resembling imposter syndrome are common…other times…there is a sense of confidence reassurance that one is capable…the experience is characterized by mixed emotions. (Interview 1)

*Foreseeing a continued learning process after graduation*

The students were aware that they would be new to the profession and that it would take time to find their place in the nurse's role. They imagined that it would be rewarding to overcome the initial insecurities and settle into the new role, comforted by the knowledge that it was normal to feel scared at first. During the introductory period, they hoped to feel supported, ensuring that no one was harmed, and to be allowed to be new on the job.

> Now I have time to feel secure... I feel that I'm ready to manage this on my own… There will always be new things…but they become easier to deal with when it's not the case that everything feels new.... (Interview 2)

Being new in the profession was seen as both challenging and rewarding. Students expected competence to develop gradually through experience and considered a reasonable workload and continuous competence development essential. They anticipated becoming experts over time, depending on their future area of practice, but not directly after graduation.

> I look forward to developing as a nurse. Feeling secure in my role. That you learn something every day. There's a small expectation that you just keep developing all the time. (Interview 5)

Observing experienced nurses seek support when needed reinforced their view of learning as a lifelong process and strengthened appreciation of workplaces that prioritize professional development.

*Experiencing challenges and concerns about their future professional practice*

A range of anticipated challenges in future nursing practice was described, involving both patient care and collaboration with colleagues. The transition from student to registered nurse was

Please cite this article as: J. Salberg et al., A qualitative exploration of nursing students' readiness to transition into the profession, Teaching and Learning in Nursing (2026), https://doi.org/10.1016/j.teln.2026.08.019

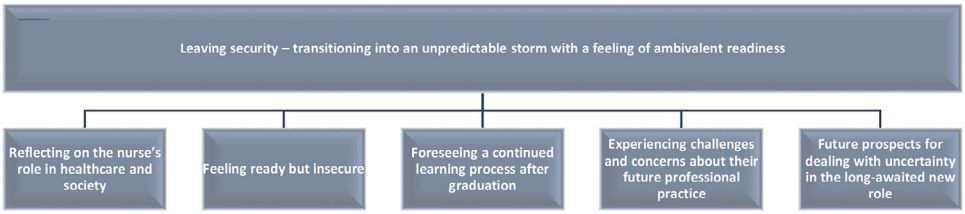



**Fig. 1.** Overarching theme and categories. Leaving security—transitioning into an unpredictable storm with a feeling of ambivalent readiness.

perceived as a point where full competence is expected, leading to fears of forgetting knowledge, making harmful mistakes, and being responsible for too many patients. They expressed internal pressure to perform professionally, contributing to stress and guilt.

> It's probably something I've thought about a lot—that there needs to be a certain pace, and there are so many patients to care for. There's this fear that you won't have enough time, or that things will take too long, or that... yes, you'll end up missing something important. (Interview 1)

Concerns included meeting patients' needs, handling ethical dilemmas, maintaining up-to-date knowledge, applying evidence-based practice, managing technical tasks, and leading nursing care.

> You're expected to learn to collaborate in a team and work closely with other professionals... but I see a challenge, being able to manage it. That...the leadership role itself. (Interview 3)

Students also worried about organizational conditions, including staff shortages, high turnover, overtime, limited recovery, and unstable work environments. They perceived hierarchical structures and frequent management changes as barriers to effective teamwork and quality improvement.

> It might be those conditions that help one feel comfortable...and reduce the risk of burnout, something that nurses perhaps don't have in abundance. It can be difficult to influence and hard to keep track of your pace. In the end...to deal with the prevailing conditions as they are...a bit challenging. (Interview 7)

Salary was another concern. Students felt that pay should reflect their education, workload, and responsibility, but were uncertain about negotiating and demonstrating their value.

### *Future prospects for dealing with uncertainty in the long-awaited new role*

Students highlighted openness about insecurities, help-seeking, and trust in their existing knowledge as important strategies for managing the transition. Independent practice was viewed positively, provided adequate support was available. Focusing on factors within their control, while accepting limitations in broader organizational issues, was considered an important coping strategy.

> I can always influence myself... shape my knowledge and decide where I choose to work. Those are things I can control... I won't be able to solve issues like staffing or whether the management is good or bad. Those are beyond my control. But I can influence my own actions and decisions, and I can choose where I want to be. That's something I have control over. (Interview 6)

Clear leadership, defined expectations, established routines, reflection, and supportive colleagues were seen as important sources of security. At the same time, students recognized that high staff turnover might limit access to experienced support. They valued the broad labor market available to nurses and felt able to seek alternative workplaces if needed.

> I think that we have...a very broad labor market. You can work in many different areas... you start at one workplace...doesn't mean you're locked into it for the rest of your life. (Interview 3)

Students looked forward to contributing to patient care and society, while continuing to develop professionally. Opportunities for specialization and lifelong learning were viewed positively, as was achieving a balance between work and personal life.

> Once I'm qualified, I want to continue developing. Pursue something more specialized, toward a particular area...that's great in healthcare you can develop a great deal. You don't have to stay in one place. You can try different types of services and build... it's really good. (Interview 3)

## Discussion

This study is unique in exploring readiness to transition among nursing students whose education during the COVID-19 pandemic was conducted mostly online. The overarching theme summarizes the students' mixed emotions as they prepared for professional practice. Students described how the pandemic reshaped their view of nursing, highlighting both its societal importance and the challenges of the profession. Their reflections align with increased public recognition of nursing while also reflecting concerns about demanding work environments (Bäckström et al., 2024). The findings suggest challenges beyond technical skills, including organizational factors that may contribute to feelings of insecurity and lack of support, consistent with previous research on new graduates' transition experiences (Hallaran et al., 2021; Zheng et al., 2022). Organizational socialization practices, such as supportive environments, professional role modeling, and recognition of individual contributions, are important for successful transitions and retention (Phillips et al., 2015). Students also emphasized the value of structured introductions and collegial support in building confidence and competence.

Ambivalence during transition is common, with students often feeling both prepared and insecure as they enter professional practice (Ingvarsson et al., 2019), which is consistent with Meleis et al.'s (2000) transition theory. While these experiences are consistent with prepandemic findings (Aukerman et al., 2022; Bani et al., 2023), the pandemic may have intensified perceptions of nursing's complexity, underscoring the need to strengthen professional identity in nursing education.

Despite global variations in learning conditions, these findings may be internationally relevant given common educational frameworks and the pandemic's worldwide impact on healthcare (Commission Delegated Directive (EU) 2024/782; Bani et al., 2023). Similar

Please cite this article as: J. Salberg et al., A qualitative exploration of nursing students' readiness to transition into the profession, Teaching and Learning in Nursing (2026), https://doi.org/10.1016/j.teln.2026.08.019

transition challenges have been reported internationally (Aukerman et al., 2022; Bani et al., 2023; Luo et al., 2023). Although students acknowledged limitations of digital learning, they rarely viewed it as affecting readiness, consistent with evidence that readiness continues to develop after graduation (Jamieson et al., 2019). The reduced emphasis on digital learning in students' accounts may reflect that interviews were conducted after restrictions had eased, shifting their focus toward current concerns. Students viewed entry into the profession as the start of a lifelong learning process, consistent with Benner's (1984) novice-to-expert model. Clinical training and high-quality education supported feelings of preparedness (Güner, 2015), while a supportive environment was considered important for ongoing learning and professional development.

A key source of anxiety was fear of making mistakes that could harm patients, particularly in relation to patient safety and responsibility (Wang, 2019). Similar concerns have been reported among nursing students and new graduates (Aukerman et al., 2022; Bani, 2023; Luo et al., 2023). Addressing these concerns in both education and clinical practice is essential. Educational programs should provide opportunities to discuss and reflect on complex clinical situations, while mentorship in practice can offer support and security during the transition to professional roles. Stress during education may further affect health and learning (Rafati et al., 2017; Zheng et al., 2022). In this study, students described relying on both organizational and personal support to manage uncertainty, consistent with evidence showing that structured transition programs and social support can reduce stress and strengthen confidence and performance (McLean et al., 2023; Reebals et al., 2022). These findings highlight the importance of mentorship, reflection, and clinical supervision in promoting readiness and a sustainable transition into practice.

## Limitations

Recruitment was challenging as the interviews were conducted during a high-stress period for students, which likely affected participation. Conducting the interviews via Zoom may have facilitated participation, but communication and group interaction might have been influenced by the digital format. However, previous research suggests that video interviews are comparable to face-to-face interviews in terms of interaction and data quality (Anthony et al., 2025; Saarijärvi & Bratt, 2021). In the present study, the consistency of participants' narratives, the open interview climate, lively discussions, and rich data support the credibility of the findings despite the limited sample. A further limitation is that all but one participant were female. It is possible that the findings may have differed with a greater proportion of male participants. Self-selection bias among more motivated students cannot be excluded due to voluntary participation. Nevertheless, the participants represented information-rich cases with varied characteristics, suitable for deepening understanding of the phenomenon under study (Patton, 2015). The carefully collected, analyzed, and described findings are therefore considered transferable to groups and contexts with similar characteristics (Patton, 2015).

## Conclusion

Students felt prepared and motivated for professional practice but were uncertain whether they would be supported in developing as novice nurses. Although their pandemic-shaped education had not diminished their competence, it had increased their awareness of the profession's complexity and the need for continued learning. These findings underscore the importance of professional guidance, structured mentorship, and professional identity development, as well as collaboration among educators, nurse managers, and policymakers to support a safe and sustainable transition into practice.

## Funding

This research did not receive any specific grant from funding agencies in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors.

## Data Availability Statement

The datasets generated and/or analyzed during the current study are not publicly available in order to protect the integrity, anonymity, and confidentiality of the respondents, with the exception that anonymized quotations supporting the data in the results section in the manuscript are shown. These are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

## Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing personal relationships or financial interests that may have influenced the study reported in this paper.

## CRediT authorship contribution statement

**Johanna Salberg:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Project administration, Methodology, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Katarina Hjelm:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Anja Saletti:** Writing – review & editing, Conceptualization. **Lisa Hultin:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Project administration, Methodology, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization.

## Acknowledgments

The authors would like to thank all the nursing students who participated in this study.

## References

AlMekkawi, M., & El Khalil, R. (2020). New graduate nurses' readiness to practise: A narrative literature review. *Health Professions Education, 6*(3), 304–316. doi:10.1016/j.hpe.2020.05.008.

Anthony, K., Miller-Day, M., Dupuy, M., Ventura, J., Hodges, A. L., Alonso-Pecora, D., & Dimas, H. (2025). Is there really a difference? A comparison of in-person and online qualitative interviews. *International Journal of Qualitative Methods, 24*, 1–13. doi:10.1177/16094069251349580.

Aukerman, R., White, L., Gierach, M., Miller, T., & Wolles, B. (2022). The lived experience of nurses transitioning to professional practice during the COVID-19 pandemic. *Nursing Forum, 57*, 756–764. doi:10.1111/nuf.12759.

Bäckström, J., Pöder, U., & Karlsson, A.-C. (2024). I was merely a brick in the game: A qualitative study on registered nurses' reasons for quitting their jobs in hospitals. *Journal of Nursing Management, 1*, 6662802. doi:10.1155/2024/6662802.

Bani, M., Russo, S., Cardinale, C., Ardenghi, S., Rampoldi, G., Luciani, M., Ausili, D., Di Mauro, S., & Strepparava, M. G. (2023). Jumping into the COVID-19 arena: The professional Transition into clinical practice of new graduate nurses in Italy at time of COVID-19. *Journal of Clinical Nursing, 32*, 3898–3908. doi:10.1111/jocn.16554.

Baumann, A., Crea-Arsenio, M., Hunsberg, M., Flemming-Caroll, B., & Keatings, M. (2019). Work readiness, transition, and integration: The challenge of specialty practice. *Journal of Advanced Nursing, 75*, 823–833. doi:10.1111/jan.13918.

Benner, P. (1984). From novice to expert: Excellence and power in clinical nursing practice. *American Journal of Nursing, 84*, 1480. doi:10.1097/00000446-198412000-00027.

Blau, A., Sela, Y., & Grinberg, K. (2023). Public perceptions and attitudes on the image of nursing in the wake of COVID-19. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health, 20*(6). doi:10.3390/ijerph20064717 Article 6.

Güner, P. (2015). Preparedness of final-year Turkish nursing students for work as a professional nurse. *Journal of Clinical Nursing, 24*(5–6), 844–854. doi:10.1111/jocn.12673.

Please cite this article as: J. Salberg et al., A qualitative exploration of nursing students' readiness to transition into the profession, Teaching and Learning in Nursing (2026), https://doi.org/10.1016/j.teln.2026.08.019

Hallaran, A. J., Edge, D. S., Almost, J., & Tregunno, D. (2021). New registered nurse transition to the workforce and intention to leave: Testing a theoretical model. *Canadian Journal of Nursing Research, 53*(4), 384–396. doi:10.1177/0844562120957845.

Heilferty, C. M., Phillips, L. J., & Mathios, R. (2021). Letters from the pandemic: Nursing student narratives of change, challenges and thriving at the outset of COVID-19. *Journal of Advanced Nursing, 77*(8), 3436–3445. doi:10.1111/jan.14862.

Ingvarsson, E., Verho, J., & Rosengren, K. (2019). Managing uncertainty in nursing—Newly graduated nurses' experiences of introduction to the nursing profession. *International Archives of Nursing and Health Care, 5*(1). doi:10.23937/2469-5823/1510119.

Jamieson, I., Sims, D., Basu, A., & Pugh, K. (2019). Readiness for practice: The views of New Zealand senior nursing students. *Nurse Education in Practice, 38*, 27–33. doi:10.1016/j.nepr.2019.05.007.

Krueger, R. A., & Casey, M. A. (2015). *Focus groups—A practical guide for applied research* (5th ed.). SAGE.

Langegård, U., Kiani, K., Nielsen, S. J., & Svensson, P.-A. (2021). Nursing students' experiences of a pedagogical transition from campus learning to distance learning using digital tools. *BMC Nursing, 20*(1), 23. doi:10.1186/s12912-021-00542-1.

Laschinger, H. K. S., Cummings, G., Leiter, M., Wong, C., MacPhee, M., Ritchie, J., Wolff, A., Regan, S., Rhéaume-Brüning, A., Jeffs, L., Young-Ritchie, C., Grinspun, D., Gurnham, M. E., Foster, B., Huckstep, S., Ruffolo, M., Shamian, J., Burkoski, V., Wood, K., & Read, E. (2016). Starting out: A time-lagged study of new graduate nurses' transition to practice. *International Journal of Nursing Studies, 57*, 82–95. doi:10.1016/j.ijnurstu.2016.01.005.

Law Concerning the Ethical Review of Research Involving Humans. (2003). *Svensk författningssamling (SFS 2003:460)*. Sveriges riksdag. Retrieved December 2025 https://www.riksdagen.se/sv/dokument-och-lagar/dokument/svensk-forfattningssamling/lag-2003460-om-etikprovning-av-forskning-som_sfs-2003-460/.

Luo, J., Luo, L., Yang, A., Cui, M., & Ma, H. (2023). Clinical experiences of final-year nursing students during the COVID-19 pandemic: A systematic review and meta-synthesis. *Nurse Education Today, 120*, e105633. doi:10.1016/j.nedt.2022.105633.

McHugh, M. D., Aiken, L. H., Sloane, D. M., Windsor, C., Douglas, C., & Yates, P. (2021). Effects of nurse-to-patient ratio legislation on nurse staffing and patient mortality, readmissions, and length of stay: A prospective study in a panel of hospitals. *The Lancet, 397*(10288), 1905–1913. doi:10.1016/S0140-6736(21)00768-6.

McLean, L., Gaul, D., & Penco, R. (2023). Perceived social support and stress: A study of 1st year students in Ireland. *International Journal of Mental Health and Addiction, 21*(4), 2101–2121. doi:10.1007/s11469-021-00710-z.

Meleis, A. I., Sawyer, L. M., Im, E.-O., Hilfinger Messias, D. K., & Schumacher, K. (2000). Experiencing transitions: An emerging middle-range theory. *Advances in Nursing Science, 23*(1), 12.

Mirza, N., Manankil-Rankin, L., Prentice, D., Hagerman, L.-A., & Draenos, C. (2019). Practice readiness of new nursing graduates: A concept analysis. *Nurse Education in Practice, 37*, 68–74. doi:10.1016/j.nepr.2019.04.009.

Patton, M. Q. (2015). *Qualitative research & evaluation methods* (4th ed.). SAGE.

Phillips, C., Esterman, A., & Kenny, A. (2015). The theory of organisational socialisation and its potential for improving transition experiences for new graduate nurses. *Nurse Education Today, 35*(1), 118–124. doi:10.1016/j.nedt.2014.07.011.

Rafati, F., Nouhi, E., Sabzehvari, S., & Dehghan-Nayyeri, N. (2017). Iranian nursing students' experience of stressors in their first clinical experience. *Journal of Professional Nursing, 33*(3), 250–257. doi:10.1016/j.profnurs.2016.09.003.

Reebals, C., Wood, T., & Markaki, A. (2022). Transition to practice for new nurse graduates: Barriers and mitigating strategies. *Western Journal of Nursing Research, 44*(4), 416–429.

Rohde, G., Johannessen, B., Maaseide, M., Flateland, S., Skisland, A. V., Moi, E. B., & Haraldstad, K. (2022). Baccalaureate nursing students' experiences of how the COVID-19 pandemic influenced learning—A mixed method study. *BMC Nursing, 21*(1), 172. doi:10.1186/s12912-022-00955-6.

Saarijärvi, M., & Bratt, E. L. (2021). When face-to-face interviews are not possible: Tips and tricks for video, telephone, online chat, and email interviews in qualitative research. *European Journal of Cardiovascular Nursing, 20*(4), 392–396. doi:10.1093/eurjcn/zvab038.

Tawash, E., Cowman, S., & Anwar, M. (2024). New graduate nurses' readiness for practice, transition and integration into the workplace: A longitudinal study with mixed methods research. *Nurse Education in Practice, 79*, 104076. doi:10.1016/j.nepr.2024.104076.

Wang, Y. (2019). Nursing students' experiences of caring for dying patients and their families: A systematic review and meta-synthesis. *Frontiers of Nursing, 6*(4), 261–272. doi:10.2478/FON-2019-0042.

World Medical Association. (2013). World Medical Association Declaration of Helsinki: Ethical principles for medical research involving human subjects. *Journal of American Medical Association, 310*(20), 2191–2194. doi:10.1001/jama.2013.281053.

Zheng, Y., Jiao, J.-R., & Hao, W.-N. (2022). Stress levels of nursing students: A systematic review and meta-analysis. *Medicine (Baltimore), 101*,(36) e30547. doi:10.1097/MD.0000000000030547.

Please cite this article as: J. Salberg et al., A qualitative exploration of nursing students' readiness to transition into the profession, Teaching and Learning in Nursing (2026), https://doi.org/10.1016/j.teln.2026.08.019